

What is a tornado?

Tornadoes are powerful, swirling, spinning winds that sometimes form beneath a storm cloud. Wherever they touch land, tornadoes sweep across the ground, leaving behind a trail of destruction. A tornado can last for just a few seconds or for more than an hour.

2 Spinning air

As warm air meets cool, swirling air high in the cloud, it starts to spin. Soon the air lower down is spinning, too.

Whirling water

When a whirling air mass passes over warm, shallow seas, it sucks up water into a funnel of air that is called a waterspout. A waterspout may have lower wind speeds than a tornado, but it can last far longer.



3 Cloud column

More of the surrounding air is pulled in and the growing tornado spins even faster. It then forms a column of twisting cloud that reaches the ground.

